



Women in Markets

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

Mastering Markets

The investment industry in India has its own set of women trailblazers—managing thousands of crores and generating immense wealth for investors. **BY SHOAIB ZAMAN**

← **INDIA'S ECONOMIC STORY** is being shaped by a force that remains under-recognised: its women. They make up nearly half the population yet contribute only 18% to GDP, a gap highlighted in a March 2025 report, *From Borrowers to Builders—Women's Role in India's Financial Growth Story*, by NITI Aayog, Cibil and MSC. This mirrors global findings. The Global Gender Gap Report 2025 shows India still lagging on economic participation, with low scores for workforce parity and leadership representation. Agrees Renuka Ramnath, Founder, Managing Director, & CEO, Multiples Alternate Asset Management: “There’s sometimes a tendency to view women as less resilient or less capable of delivering on a par as their peers. This is evident in various ways, including how professionals are compensated, assumptions about career commitment, and the way talent is perceived.”

Yet the ground is shifting. Younger women are entering the workforce in greater numbers. Globally, women aged 16–28 account for almost half of all working women, according to the World Economic Forum. More are joining finance, investment, and capital market verticals, even if progress remains slow. Inside Indian corporations, the ‘broken rung’ persists: for every 100 men promoted to managerial roles, only 81 women move up, as noted in *Women in the Workplace 2024* by McKinsey.

Women who have reached the top in the investing world have done so by overcoming structural hurdles and cultural expectations. Devina Mehra, Founder of First Global, and Lakshmi Iyer, Group President-Investments and CEO of Bajaj Alternates, are often held up as examples. Their journeys show what is possible but also how much remains unfinished. And the new frontiers are being expanded by women who are not only rising the corporate ladder but also building institutions, re-designing systems, and creating opportunities for others—leaders such as Radhika Gupta, CEO of Edelweiss Mutual Fund and Madhu Lunawat, Founder, MD and CEO of The Wealth Company, whose experiences reveal how the industry is evolving.

BREAKING THE GLASS CEILING

The arc of Devina Mehra’s career reads like a blueprint for defying convention in a male-dominated industry. A gold medallist from IIM Ahmedabad, she joined Citibank to find she was the only woman officer in its investment banking division. “Gender simply didn’t matter in my mind,” recalls Mehra. Her early career took shape in roles where women were almost absent. She lived in shared accommodation with male colleagues, worked in trading